

at one another with broad swords, while fending off blows with their shields. The adoption of full plate armour, which was itself as hard as a sword blade and curved to deflect blows, made shields redundant. The only way a sword could harm a knight was with a thrust of the point through one of the joints in the armour. More effective were the mace and the formidable war-hammer. A blow on the helmet with one of these percussive weapons could stun the knight inside, disabling him without need to penetrate his armour. To their humiliation, mounted knights often proved vulnerable to foot soldiers. They rarely succeeded in adequately protecting their horses, especially against arrows, and being unhorsed in the middle of a battle was often a fatal experience. In practice, especially in western Europe, knights increasingly dismounted for combat, fighting as armoured infantry.



◀ HERALDIC SIGNS

This 15th-century illumination shows a knight riding a horse, which is wearing a red caparison (cloth). The shields display a heraldic device: such devices were both a mark of status and a practical means of identification.

“When battle is joined let all noble knights think nothing of the breaking of heads and arms, for it is better to die than be vanquished and live”

BERTRAN DE BORN, FRENCH TROUBADOUR, c.1140–1215



KEY EVENTS

1000–1500

- **1081** Norman horsemen use the charge with couched lance against Byzantine forces at the Battle of Dyrrhachium.
- **From 1096** European knights fight Crusades to secure Christian states in Palestine and Syria.
- **1000–1500** Spanish knights fight the wars of the Reconquista, wresting Iberia from Muslim rule.
- **1350** The visored basinet becomes standard for knights.
- **c.1350** Full plate armour comes into general use for European knights; meanwhile, war-hammers are introduced as a means of attacking it.
- **1337–1453** The kings of England and France fight a series of conflicts known as the Hundred Years' War.

◀ A SWORD BATTLE

This 14th-century illustration shows sword-armed knights wearing basinet helmets and mail, with plate armour covering their vulnerable arms, torso, and legs. Cloth surcoats helped keep their armour cooler in the sun.